

AN AFRICAN GOLD NOVEL
THE SPIRITUAL FOURTH

AFRIKA 2100

They were never here for the gold.

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ARJUNA BADGER PRESS

Witwatersrand, west of Randfontein • Landing Day, 2071

She was at the third benchmark by half past four, which was earlier than the job needed and later than she had wanted.

The brass plug was where it had been in 2069, set into a concrete block the size of a bread loaf, stamped **TR/W-114**. Dineo brushed the grit off with her thumb, seated the tripod, and levelled up. Tebogo held the staff at the backsight and complained about the cold in two languages.

“You could have taken leave,” she said.

“Everybody took leave. There’s nobody left to take leave from.”

“Then hold it plumb.”

Overhead the object had not moved in any way a person standing still could measure. It had been up there since she was forty-four. Her sister had cried about it for a week in 2066 and then stopped, and now made jokes about it at Christmas, and this was the general history of the country’s feeling on the matter.

Closure on the morning traverse came out at eleven millimetres over 2.4 kilometres. Acceptable. She wrote it in the field book in pencil, because ink runs and pencil doesn’t, and because her supervisor in 2041 had rapped her knuckles for using a pen and she had never once forgiven him or gone back to ink.

The gravimeter went in at the fourth station, on the pad she had

poured herself in April. Base reading logged 05:12. She would take it again every hour until the thing was on the ground and every hour after that until dark. The Department wanted to know whether the reef moved. Two hundred metres of old stope work lay under this veld, mined out, flooded, and abandoned before her grandmother was born, and if you set anything heavy on the roof of that you might find out what a sinkhole thinks. Nobody in the country had been able to say what the object weighed. The estimates on the radio ran from four hundred tonnes to nine thousand.

“They should have landed it on the Free State,” Tebogo said. “Flat. Solid. Boring.”

“They didn’t ask me.”

“They asked somebody.”

They had, in fact, asked. Coordinates had come down through the mesh in March, in three formats, one of them a format nobody had used since 2038, and the Department had spent five weeks arguing about whether to counter-propose. In the end the Minerals people looked at the old plans and said the ground would hold and the Department said fine, and a fence went up, and Dineo poured her pads.

By seven the radio in the bakkie had gone over to the outside broadcast and she could hear the crowd on the ridge behind her without turning round. Chairs. Somebody’s speaker. A boy shouting the same word over and over for the pleasure of hearing it come back off the mine dump.

The station had put a cricket commentator on it. This turned out to be the correct decision, because he was the only man in Johannesburg trained to describe something arriving slowly for six hours without lying about the pace. He described the light on the underside. He described the fence. He described a woman selling boiled eggs at the cordon and gave her name and the price of the eggs, which had gone up.

“Now, if you’re joining us in the North,” he said, “I’m told you’ve got sound only, so let me do this properly for you. It is a clear morning here on the reef. Wind from the southwest, light. The object is

presently at, they tell me, eleven thousand metres and coming down at about the speed of a lift in a government building.”

Then a professor came on and said the descent was consistent with the profile published in 2066, and had been consistent every day for five years, and that the interesting question was not the descent.

Then a man from Krugersdorp phoned in to read numbers.

He read them well. He had the published telemetry in front of him and he read the ephemeris the way other men read football results: the object’s track back through 2070, 2069, 2068, and Diri’s tapes before that, the whole beautiful boring line of it, and he got as far as the burn.

“August 2061,” he said. “That’s the deceleration onset off the tapes. Peer-reviewed, twice. I’ll say it again because nobody says it. August 2061.”

“And the note was sung in June 2064,” said the presenter warmly, “so we know exactly why they’re here, and I’ll tell you what, my brother, when I was a boy nobody sang for me like that.”

The caller said something about the numbers. The presenter thanked him for the numbers. The next caller wanted to talk about whether it was a public holiday.

Dineo took the 07:12 gravity reading and wrote it down.

The taxis stopped at about half past nine. Nothing announced it. She noticed the sound of the R28 change and looked up and the traffic on it was cars only, and then not even cars. Government instructions had achieved nothing all week. The rank achieved it in an hour, because the drivers wanted to see, and once the drivers wanted to see, the country stopped.

Her nephew Sipho arrived on foot at ten with three litres of water, a bag of oranges, and the news that his mother had bought out the spaza.

“Everything?”

“Mealie meal, tinned pilchards, candles, batteries.” He counted on his fingers. “Sugar.”

“She remembers ’64.”

“She remembers ’65,” he said, which was the worse year, and put the oranges in the shade under the bakkie.

He stayed. He was nineteen and had never known the sky without it. She put him on the levelling staff so that Tebogo could go and eat, and he held it straight, and he watched the object the entire time over the top of the staff, and did not once let it wander.

At 11:04 she took the reading. Nothing. The gravimeter is a drift instrument and its drift that morning was ordinary and dull, and she noted the drift, and she noted the temperature, and she noted that the object’s shadow had reached the fence line on the western side.

It set down at 13:26.

There was no wind from it. That was the thing she had not expected and the thing she would be asked about for the rest of her life. No dust. It came the last thirty metres slower than the last hundred, and the veld under it did not move, and the grass did not lie down, and then it was on the ground with its mass on the ground, and a noise came across the flat to her that she would put in the report as a *low tone, approximately 40 Hz, duration under two seconds, cause undetermined* and which sounded to her, at the time, like a large door in a big empty building being closed by someone being careful.

The crowd on the ridge made no sound for a moment. Then it made an enormous sound, and then it went back to talking.

Dineo watched the gravimeter.

Eleven microgal. Then eight. Then, over four minutes, it settled and sat down at a new number and stayed there. Tilt at the two pads: 3.1 and 2.6 arc seconds, west-down, no rate. The old stopes had taken it. She had expected them to and had not been sure, and she wrote all of it down, station by station, in order, with the times, in pencil.

“Auntie,” Siphos said. “Is that it?”

“That’s it.”

“Should I put the staff down?”

“Put the staff down. Come and eat.”

Behind them a woman was crying and laughing at once and telling someone on the phone to be quiet and just *listen*, and a man with a portable set had turned it up so that the ridge could hear the studio, where a panel booked five years ago had finally run out of things to say and was reading messages instead.

Sipho ate an orange and said, “They came here.”

“Mm.”

“Not to America. Not to China. Here.” He was grinning. He was not making an argument; he was younger than the approach and he had grown up under it and it had come down on his ground, in his lifetime, on a Thursday. “That has to mean something about us, Auntie. Hey? They chose. That means something about *us*.”

Old Ntate Molefi, two chairs along, said, “It means the coordinates were good.”

“It means something about us,” Sipho said again, happily, and nobody on that ridge argued him down, and the woman with the phone said *amen* absently, still listening to the studio, and somebody further along said that G should have seen this, and somebody else said he did see it, meaning the arithmetic, and both of them were right and neither of them cared to fight about it.

Dineo took the 14:00 reading.

The delegates went in at four.

They had been at the Rand Show grounds for three days in a marquee, arguing about who would speak first, and in the end the order was alphabetical by delegation in French, which pleased nobody and was therefore adopted. The radio carried all of it because the radio carried everything that day. Dineo listened while she re-ran the levelling loop, because the ground had moved and the ground now needed measuring again, and because a person can only look at a thing for so long.

They asked about weapons. Answer: a statement of carried systems by category, three items, with tolerances, and a declared refusal to

discuss capability.

They asked about origin. Answer: a bearing, an approximate transit duration, and a refusal on the location.

They asked whether we are alone. Answer: no.

The ridge went up like a stadium at that and Dineo missed the next four questions.

They asked whether there is a god. Long pause on the tape, which the whole world afterwards agreed was the most human moment of the day and which was, on the recording, four and a half seconds of room noise. Answer: *the question is not one we are competent to hold.*

They asked intentions. Answer: a manifest. A list of quantities of worked gold at stated purities, a schedule, and the word *renewal*, which was in the second sentence and which the translators fought over for a decade.

They asked, again and again, in six languages, whether the note had brought them, and the answer each time was at protocol level and did not say yes, and every delegation in the marquee wrote down yes.

A delegate from the East African bloc asked if they had a name for themselves. Answer: a designation, eleven characters, given twice.

By six o'clock people in the marquee had begun to say *Anunnaki* out loud, first as a joke and then not as a joke, because it was the oldest word anybody had for people who come a long way for gold to mend a dying thing, and the fit made the hair stand up on your arms. The visitors did not accept it. They did not correct it either. They let it sit on the table like a hat somebody else had put there.

Nobody asked what they needed.

Dineo noticed, in the way you notice a missing bolt, and said so to Tebogo while she packed the prism: that when a client comes onto your site the first thing you ask is what he needs and the second thing is what it will cost to do it properly, and that they had done neither in nine hours.

"They asked about weapons," Tebogo said.

"They asked about weapons."

“Well.” He shut the case. “The meat won’t cook itself.”

He was quoting somebody’s uncle from the morning phone-in, and it was already the funniest sentence in the country, and it stayed the funniest sentence in the country for seventy years.

The braai smoke came up off the ridge at dusk and the taxis started running again at about four the next morning, which is to say the day ended the way days end.

Dineo sat in the bakkie with the door open and the field book on her knee and the reading lamp on and worked through the day’s stations in order, transferring them onto the Department’s forms in her small upright hand: TR/W-114 through the loop and back, times, temperatures, closure, the eleven microgal, the tilt at both pads, the 40 Hz tone with *cause undetermined*, the new datum. All of it true. She initialled each page.

Before dawn that morning, an hour before she seated the tripod at the third benchmark, she had walked out past the fence line to a place that was not a station.

Her pencil stopped above the next ruled line.

The lamp buzzed. On the ridge somebody’s speaker was playing music now, and the crowd was thinning, and Sipho was asleep in the tray with his jacket over his face.

She looked at the line for a while. Then she took the pencil away, closed the field book on it, and put the book in the canvas bag and the bag under the seat, and she did not write it down, then or afterwards, for twenty-seven years.

The forms went in on Monday.

By Tuesday she had four requests: a site plan at 1:500 for the cordon, a levelling datum the delegations could all agree to use, a footprint boundary to three decimals for the ledger, and a note from a man in Pretoria asking whether the Department’s monument stamps could be re-cut, since TR/W-114 now sat inside a restricted area and the numbering would have to change.

She re-cut the numbering. It took eleven days.

8WITWATERSRAND, WEST OF RANDFONTEIN · LANDING DAY, 2071

eGoli Spaceport, Berthing Floor Four • six weeks to Renewal

The first thing Naledi did on shift was mistrust her own ear.

The reference bar lived in a steel case bolted to the wall outside the choir line, and the case had a temperature log, and the log had to be initialled, and the bar had to be struck with the wooden mallet and not with a knuckle, no matter how clever your knuckle. She struck it. She held the earpiece off, listened raw, wrote *A-440 ok by ear* in the book, then put the earpiece on and let the counter tell her she was eleven millihertz optimistic.

Eleven. She wrote that down too. Some mornings she was flat, most mornings she was sharp, and in nine years she had never once been right, which was the whole reason for the mallet and the case and the log.

"You're sharp," said Thandeka, coming past with two coffees and giving her neither.

"I'm sharp before eight. After eight I'm a saint."

"You're sharp at fifty. My mother was sharp at eighty. It's genetic and it's ugly."

The floor smelled the way it always smelled: hot platcap bank, cold rock, machine oil, and the sweetish burnt note off the gantry brakes that everybody claimed to hate and nobody ever complained about in writing. Under the smell was the noise, which was not noise once you

had lived in it. Floor Four hummed. Gallery air came up through the grating at eighteen degrees and made a broad grey sound in the low sixties. The e-grav hoists over Bay Two sang thin and high while their rotors were up, and dropped out of hearing when the freight settled. Footfall pavers clicked under everybody's boots, harvesting whatever a person's weight was worth, which was almost nothing, which was the point. Waste no motion. It was written on the wall in the concourse in three languages and a man had been paid too much money to design the lettering.

Naledi loved it here in a way she had given up trying to explain to people at parties.

The choir line was nine stalls in a row against the west wall, each one a lead-lined box the size of a shower, each with its driver ring, its pickups, its little brass door with a proper handle because the guild's founders had come out of harvester engineering and did not trust anything that opened by itself.

Worked gold went in. A reading came out. That was the job, and it took nine years to learn and about forty seconds to describe.

Lot seven of the Kenyan consignment was already sitting in Stall Three under custody seal, thirty-one kilograms, formed to what the manifest called a Class-B ring blank and what everybody on the floor called a doughnut. Naledi broke the seal in front of the Steward on duty, because that was the order — Steward first, engineer second, ledger third — and the Steward wrote the time.

Tefo, that morning. He was her age and he stood like a much older man.

"Morning, ntate."

"Morning." He watched her hands. He always watched her hands. She had decided years ago that this was not suspicion but a kind of attendance, the way her mother watched a pot.

She seated the doughnut on the spider, dogged it down finger-tight and then a quarter turn, and ran the sweep. Twelve seconds of rising drive, the pickups reading back, the counter building its picture. The stall answered. It always sounded to her like a struck glass held under

water: not a note, a *place* where notes went.

Fundamental within four millihertz of the Accord figure. Second and third partials where they should be. Q high. The decay curve came up on the screen and lay down over the reference envelope like a hand into a glove.

“Clean,” she said. “Beautiful, actually. Whoever formed this one wasn’t rushing.”

“Nairobi,” Tefo said.

“Well. Tell Nairobi.” She keyed the sign-off, thumb on the plate, and the ledger took it and gave her back a receipt hash she would never look at and could never alter. *Put it on the ledger and it’s out of your hands* — half the guild’s manuals opened with a line like that, and half the guild recited them like grace before food, which Baba Siphosaid was fine as long as they also read the appendices.

Lot eight failed.

Not dramatically. Eight was a plate, eleven kilos, and its fundamental sat nineteen millihertz low with a partial smeared out into a fat little hill that had no business being there. Naledi ran it twice, changed the seating, ran it again, and got the same hill.

Karabo, who was two months out of the academy and would be excellent in about four years, leaned in and said, “Contamination?”

“Sometimes.”

“Silver?”

“Sometimes it’s silver, sometimes it’s a void, sometimes the tolerance on the forming press walked in the night and nobody told anybody.” She flagged it, wrote *reject, partial structure at 2f, recommend section and re-melt*, and let the stall wind down. “Don’t guess in the box. Guess in the canteen.”

“So what is it?”

“I think it’s a void.” She shrugged. “In the canteen.”

Tefo wrote the time on the reject and did not say anything, and the plate went back into custody, and somewhere in Kenya a foreman was going to have a bad Tuesday. That was the trade. The visitors

bought worked gold at stated purity in stated forms to stated tolerances, and they did not haggle, and they did not accept substitutes, and in twenty-seven years no consignment had ever been refused at the pad, because the guild refused it here first. Baba Sipho put it plainly at every induction: *we are the last people who can still say no cheaply.*

The hull for Bay One came in at 11:40, which was 11:40, because it always was.

Naledi went up on the catwalk to watch, along with everyone else who could invent a reason. The gallery mouth is a vitrified bore forty metres across, glassed by something nobody has explained in seventy years of trying, and the catwalk runs straight through it, and she had walked that catwalk so many times that she only sometimes remembered to be amazed. The hull came over the apron without wind. She had heard her grandmother describe that once, on the radio programme they replayed every Landing Day, in the voice of a woman being asked about weather.

Protocol came through on the floor board in the usual form.

BERTH ONE. MASS AT CONTACT 3,410 TONNES. CLEARANCE REQUESTED 4 METRES. HOLD 6 HOURS 40 MINUTES. UPLIFT LOT SCHEDULE 44-C, NINE ITEMS, PURITY AS FILED, FORM AS FILED. TOLERANCE UNCHANGED.

“Tolerance unchanged,” Thandeka read out. “Every time. As if we’d wake up one morning and start rounding.”

“They’re a freight company,” Naledi said. “You’ve met freight companies.”

“I’ve met freight companies who send flowers.”

The liaison’s countersign came a minute later, six lines, signed *Sela*, and one of the lines noted that item four of 44-C had been re-formed since filing and asked that the tolerance be verified against the filed figure rather than the re-formed drawing. Which was correct. Which was, in fact, exactly what Naledi would have asked for in their position, and she had a small private habit of noting when the counterparty was being careful, because on a floor where everybody talked about the

visitors as an event, it was steady to remember they were also a client with a paperwork culture.

Karabo, chin on the rail: "Do you ever think they're watching us work?"

"They're watching the load," Naledi said. "Which is us working."

She ate outside, on the wall by the east cordon, because the canteen had the sound of eighty people and no ceiling treatment and after five hours of pickups her ears wanted grass.

The fence there is chain-link, four metres, with the pilgrim gate at the end of it, and by noon there were maybe sixty people along it. Ordinary. Some had come for the hull; you could see the hull's upper curve from that stretch, and people held children up. Some had come for the other thing. A woman was pressing a coin against the wire and holding it there with her palm flat, eyes shut, and further down two men had chalked the sentence on the pavement and were arguing about whether the short form counted.

The coins were the ledger coins, the ones with G's face on the obverse, worn smooth around the jaw from exactly this. Naledi had one in a drawer at home from her confirmation, which had been a Fold confirmation on her father's side and a very tense lunch on her mother's.

A young man came along the fence with a clipboard, doing it politely, and asked her whether she worked inside.

"I do."

"Then can I ask you," he said, "what would he have signed?"

He meant the Renewal. He meant it seriously; he had a lanyard and a printed sheet and the patience of somebody who had asked forty people already.

"I don't know," Naledi said. "He died before the Flare. He never saw any of it."

"He saw the arithmetic."

"He saw some of the arithmetic." She wrapped the rest of her bread. "Ask me what the tolerance on item four is. I'll tell you to three places

and you'll be bored."

He wrote something down anyway. She hoped it was *bored*.

Her mother left a voice note at two, which the mesh delivered in a burst when Naledi came out of Stall Six.

Ausi, the man from the Department phoned again about Gogo's field books. I told him the family has them and the family is not a library. Phone your brother, he thinks I was rude.

Fourteen books. Canvas-bound, pencil throughout, initialled at the foot of every page in a small upright hand, and in the margins of four of them a set of bearings and offsets that did not correspond to any monument in the register. Naledi had photographed those pages when she was twenty-three, for reasons she could not now reconstruct, and never shown them to anybody at the port, for reasons she also could not reconstruct.

Gogo Dineo had surveyed the landing ground. Everybody knew that. Every Landing Day somebody played the tape. And she had sat in her chair in Qwaqwa with her ankles swollen and answered every question a granddaughter could think of about datums, closure, and the correct way to hold a staff, and none at all about anything else, and she died in 2098 with her mouth shut and her handwriting intact.

Naledi put the earpiece back in and went to lot four.

Handover at seventeen hundred.

She read the numbers out to Lebo off the book and not off the screen, because that was the discipline: *lots seven through fifteen signed, lot eight rejected for partial structure at 2f, stall three driver ring at nine hundred hours since service, stall six pickup two reading two millihertz proud all afternoon and I've noted it, floor idle logged at fourteen-hundred, uplift 44-C staged, item four verified against filed.*

"Pickup two proud," Lebo said. "Proud how?"

"Proud like a cousin with a new car. Two millihertz. It's in the book."

"You want it changed out?"

“I want it watched.” She signed. Lebo signed. The ledger took both and gave nothing back.

She hung the earpiece on its hook, put the mallet in its clip, initialled the temperature log for the reference bar on the way out, and stood for a second in the doorway with her jacket half on.

The floor was doing what it does in the evening: gallery air coming up grey and broad, one hoist still spinning down over Bay Two, a hull sitting on its pad with its mass on the ground and the room’s idle sitting under all of it, the sound she had worked inside since she was nineteen.

She hummed against it, the way you touch a wall to see if it’s wet.

Then she went up the stairs and out through the concourse where the pavers clicked, and got on the tram, and gave up her seat to a man with a cooler box, and rode home with her fingers going on her knee, still holding the pitch she had hummed, trying it against the pitch she had walked out with. Nothing she could put a number to. Not enough for the book.

Sharp before eight, she thought. Sharp at five, apparently. Genetic and ugly.

She let it go twice on the way home and picked it up again both times.

Lancaster Compact zone, Gordonville depot • six weeks to Renewal

The scale said 908 kilograms and the manifest said 908 kilograms, so Ruth signed the manifest.

That was the third weighing. First at the mint in Philadelphia, second at the rail transfer in Coatesville, third here on the depot platform scale that the Compact used for hog lots and hay and now for this. She had asked for the third weighing herself. Nobody argued. A quartermaster who signs on two weighings is a quartermaster explaining herself to a board in six months.

Twenty-two cases. Each case forty-one kilos of worked gold and eleven of crate. Ash crates, dovetailed, no nails in the corners, made in Intercourse by a shop that mostly built grain wagons. Steel banding. Custody seals on the bands, wire-and-lead, the old kind, because the Accord wanted a seal a man could look at.

She walked the row and put her hand flat on each lid. Not for anything. It is what you do.

“Load’s good, Captain,” Beiler said.

“Load’s good. Wagon.”

They went and looked at the wagon.

It was a gun carriage. It had been a gun carriage in 2066 when the

Army moved field pieces out of Carlisle to sit on the granary roads, and the barrel had gone for scrap in the seventies, and the trail and the axle and the wheels had stayed because nothing built for a gun ever wears out doing anything else. The shop at New Holland had decked it, cross-braced it, hung new sides, and fitted piezo struts in place of the leaf springs, so the ruts on the Blue Ball road would put something back into the cells under the seat.

Two teams of Belgians. Four horses. Sixteen hundred kilos of animal for nine hundred of cargo, which the young men found funny and which Ruth did not, because the animals were the part that would still be working if every cell in the county went flat.

"Reuben says the offside wheeler is short in the shoulder," Beiler said.

"Is he."

"He says it. He's been saying it a week."

"Change him out."

"Reuben doesn't want him changed out. He wants it on the record that he said it."

"Then put it on the ledger and keep the horse." Ruth crouched by the hub and turned the wheel a quarter and listened to the bearing. "Tell Reuben I put it on myself."

Beiler wrote it in his book. He wrote everything in a book. He was forty-four and had been Plain until he was twenty-two and was still Plain in every way that mattered to a load: he did not hurry, he did not shout, and he could tell you the weight of a thing by looking at it and be within five kilos.

The blessing was at seven, before the heat.

Two hundred people came, which was more than she wanted and fewer than she had feared. The depot yard filled up along the fence, and the school let out for it, and somebody's Assist frame stood at the back with its arms folded, and the man in it apologised twice for the noise of the joints, which was nothing, which was less noise than the children.

Bishop's daughter's husband led it. That was how it worked now; the Fold has no ordination and it keeps the shape of the households it grew out of. His name was Eli Hoover and he sold seed.

He stood on the platform scale, which Ruth noticed and liked, because it meant he was being weighed.

He read the folded passage about the corn of wheat. Then the one out of the second book of the Ledger, the ninth kindness, the one about the neighbour's ox and the neighbour's roof, which in the folded text has the ox and the roof and then the sentence, and the sentence is *be kind*.

She had heard him read it before with the whole line in it. Not this morning. Two hundred people and the school children in the front.

The gathering said it back the way a gathering does: half a beat behind, some in Deutsch, some not, the two languages sliding over each other and coming out even.

Sei gut. Be kind.

Ruth said it. She said it with her hat off and her hand on the wagon side, because the wagon was what they were blessing, and she meant it, and she also stood there with the other half of it in her mouth like a stone.

Eli Hoover put his hand on the near case.

"This is not a tribute," he said. "We don't know what it is. We're sending it because we said we would, and because they asked for the work and not the metal, and that's a thing we understand — a man who wants your work is dealing straight with you."

Somebody said amen.

"It might be payment," he said. "It might be a gift. Captain Stoltzfus is going to find out and come back and tell us, and we'll believe her, because she doesn't say things twice."

Ruth kept her eyes on the case bands. That was not the arrangement. The arrangement was that she was quartermaster of a consignment and would deliver it into the port's custody and obtain a receipt. But she did not correct a man in front of his own gathering over a load,

and she noted that she had not corrected him, and she knew she would think about that on the water.

Then the horses were prayed for by name. That is the Plain part and it has never left. Dan, Jake, Sadie, and the offside wheeler, whose name was Hosea and who was short in the shoulder.

The children sang. Two verses and a chorus, nothing anybody in Africa would recognise as a hymn — the tune had come from a hunger-year work song and everybody knew it and nobody knew who made it.

Her mother did not come. Her mother was three miles up the Musser road and eighty-one and had said in April that she would not stand in a yard and watch the Army bless gold.

Her brother did not come either. Levi was fifteen miles away and had been fifteen miles away for twenty-three years. He had stayed; she had gone. He farmed her father's ground and did it better than her father had. They wrote. He signed his letters *your brother Levi* and asked after her back.

She had gone up on Saturday and sat in the kitchen and eaten pie and been asked nothing about the consignment, and had answered nothing, and it had been a good afternoon.

At half past eight the yard emptied and she went round the wagon alone with the checklist on the clipboard, which was paper, because paper does not need a cell.

Bands: twenty-two, seals intact, numbers matched to the manifest. Chocks: in. Brake shoes: clean and dry. Struts: four, charging, needle moving. Cell bank under the seat: at sixty-one percent, which was fine, which was better than fine for a wagon that was going to spend nine days on Compact roads before it saw a railhead. Water: forty litres for the animals, tarpaulined. Feed: eleven bags oats, four bales. Escort: six, mounted, small arms, plus Beiler. Rifles: seven, cleaned last night in front of her. Bible: her grandmother's, German, in the flat pocket of her duffel, where it had been since Fort Lee.

She got to the bottom of the list and stood a minute in the shadow of

the wagon with the yard smelling of horse and dust and the platform scale ticking as it cooled.

She took the coin out of her breast pocket.

It was a ledger coin, worn to a soft brown on the high spots, his face on the obverse rubbed down mostly to the jaw and the eye socket. On the reverse the two sentences, small caps, all the way round the rim, the way the honest ones have them.

DON'T BE A CUNT. BE KIND.

She read it. She read it every time. There was no ceremony in it; it took two seconds; it was the same as putting a hand on a lid.

The soft form is a kindness to children and grandmothers and she had no argument with it. She had watched it happen in her own lifetime — the coins with the word filed off, then the coins struck without it, then the passages read short in company and long alone, and half the gatherings in the county now with the full line on the wall in the back room and *BE KIND* over the door.

It is a warning first. That was all. The first sentence tells you what you will do without trying, and the second tells you what will cost you something. Take the first one out and you are left with a nice idea and no floor under it.

She put the coin back in her pocket and buttoned the pocket.

She was not baptised in. She had been nine weeks from it at eighteen and had gone to the recruiter in Lancaster instead, and no one in her family had ever once made it into a wound in front of her, which was its own kind of pressure. She had a coin and no baptism and a German Bible she could read slower than she could shoot.

Beiler brought her the road order at nine, and the weather off the mesh, and a peach.

"Ninety-one today," he said. "Ninety-four Thursday."

"We'll water at Blue Ball and Gap."

"Reuben says Gap has the trough out for repair."

"Then Reuben knows where the next water is and he'll tell me at Blue Ball." She ate the peach. It was a good peach. "Amos."

"Captain."

"When we get there. If I'm asked to stand up and say what this is."

He waited. He was good at that.

"I don't know what it is," she said.

"No."

"Eli said I'd find out."

"Eli sells seed," Beiler said. "He also sells hope, and he doesn't charge for it, so it comes out about even." He put the peach stone in his pocket rather than the yard. "You'll say what you saw."

"That's the whole of it?"

"That's the whole of it. You've never been any good at the other."

She walked the row of cases one last time, twenty-two lids, hand flat on each.

Then she climbed up and took the seat on the left because Reuben drove and a quartermaster does not drive, and Reuben said something to the near team, low, in Deutsch, that was not an order and not a prayer.

The chocks came out. The wheelers took the weight; the leaders leaned into it; the trail creaked at the pin and the whole nine hundred kilos came off the platform apron and onto the gravel, and the needles on the strut gauges jumped as the first rut took the offside wheel.

Somebody's dog came out of the depot office and ran the length of the fence with them, barking, and gave up at the gate.

They went out the Gordonville road at four miles an hour, east into the sun, with the escort at a walk behind and the dust standing up in the ditch grass and not settling until they were past the schoolhouse.

eGoli Spaceport, Berthing Floor Four • six weeks to Renewal

The discrepancy came out of a housekeeping job nobody wanted.

Uplift 44-C had gone out on the Thursday hull and the guild's part of it was closed, but the Accord's annexes require the tuning house to reconcile each uplift against the counterparty's stated use, once, within seven days, and file the reconciliation. It is a paper exercise. The visitors file a repair manifest for every consignment: item, form, mass, and a use-line saying which component the metal is for. The guild files back a resonance sheet saying what each item measured. The two go into the ledger side by side and nobody reads them again, ever, in the whole history of the trade.

Naledi drew it because she had lost a bet about a rugby match.

She took the terminal in the tuning office, which is a converted store cupboard with a window onto the gallery mouth and a kettle that trips the ring main if anyone runs the desk lamp at the same time. She had the lamp off. She had 44-C's nine resonance sheets on the left of the screen and the manifest on the right, and a mug going cold at her elbow, and she was going to be finished by four.

Item one. Ring blank, 62.4 kg, use-line: *guide segment, ring assembly, class 3*. Sheet: fundamental 212.113 Hz, partials clean, Q high.

Item two. Plate. Use-line: *coupling face, secondary*. Sheet: 388.006.

Item three, four, five. Fine.

Item six was a ring blank too. Same class, same nominal mass within a kilo, same use-line word for word: *guide segment, ring assembly, class 3*.

Fundamental 212.098.

Naledi looked at that for a while.

Fifteen millihertz is nothing. Fifteen millihertz is her own ear before eight in the morning. Two ring blanks formed to the same drawing in two different shops on two different presses will differ by more than that, and the tolerance band in the annex is generous by design, because the visitors buy to a tolerance and not to a number, and the guild's whole existence is the width of that band.

But the guild does not read the band. The guild reads the *shape*.

She pulled up the two decay envelopes and put them one over the other. Item one's third partial came down like a dropped stone. Item six's third partial came down and then sat, for about four hundred milliseconds, on a shelf.

She had seen that shelf before. Everybody had. It is what a driven mass does when it is coupled to something that wants to keep ringing at a slightly different pitch — a stall with a loose spider, a plate that has been seated against the lead lining, a pickup two millihertz proud. It is a coupling artefact and the correct response is to reseal and rerun, and if it recurs, service the stall.

Item six had been read in Stall Five. Item one in Stall Five. Same stall, same morning, same engineer — Lebo, who was better at this than Naledi and had signed both without a note.

She got up, went out onto the floor, and reseated nothing, because both items were four hundred and eleven kilometres up and out.

So she did it the long way, which took nine days and mostly happened between other things.

She pulled every reconciliation for every consignment of the last three years. Two hundred and sixty-one uplifts, one thousand nine

hundred and forty items. The ledger holds them all and the ledger is not slow; the slow part is that the use-lines are free text.

The visitors write their manifests in protocol English and their protocol English is exact but it is not a database schema. *Guide segment, ring assembly, class 3. Guide segment (ring), class three. Ring assembly guide, cl.3, replacement.* Naledi spent two evenings building a table by hand to collapse the variants, and she built it in pencil first, on the back of a stall service log, because that was faster than arguing with software.

Then she sorted every item in the three years by use-line and looked at the resonance sheets grouped that way.

The class-3 guide segments came out in two families.

Not a spread. Two clumps, with a gap between them you could park a hull in. Family A sat around 212.113 and had clean fast decay. Family B sat fifteen to nineteen millihertz low, always low, never high, and every single one of them had the shelf on the third partial.

Two hundred and six class-3 guide segments in three years. Ninety-one in family B.

She sat back and the chair squeaked and she said, out loud, to the kettle, "Oh, that's not nice."

Because a use-line is a *use*. It says what the metal is for. And if the counterparty is buying two acoustically distinct components and filing both under one use-line, then either they have a sloppy clerk, or the two families go to two different places, and the manifest is not describing the second place.

She checked the sloppy clerk hypothesis, because you do. She sorted family B by filing date, by forming shop, by mass, by purity, by the shipping hull, by the day of the week. Family B came from Kenya and Australia and the Bushveld and Chile and one lot out of Aksum. Family B included items formed to the drawing by four presses that had never made anything else. Family B ran all three years with no trend, roughly two in five, and the split held to within a couple of percent across every quarter she cut.

Nobody's clerk is that consistent. Consistency is the fingerprint of a system.

She did the last check on the ninth evening with the lamp off and the kettle unplugged. She took the twelve family-B items with the most complete sheets and looked not at the fundamental but at the interval between family A and family B: 212.113 against 212.098, 388.006 against 387.978, 145.220 against 145.209.

She worked the ratios on paper. They came out the same to four places. Same interval, every pair, every form, three years. Family B was not a family of flawed parts. Family B was family A transposed — the whole set shifted down by one fixed, tiny, deliberate amount.

You do not get that from voids. You do not get that from silver. You get that from somebody forming metal to a *different reference pitch* and calling it the same component.

Naledi's stomach did the thing it does on a hoist.

She wrote it up properly. She had it in her hands by eleven that night and she did not send it, because at eleven at night everybody is a genius. She read it again at half past six with the reference bar log in front of her and her ear eleven millihertz optimistic as usual, and it still stood up.

Discrepancy report. Guild form 12. Observation, method, data appendix, and one recommendation: *that the tuning house request clarification from the liaison as to whether use-line "guide segment, ring assembly, class 3" covers two distinct component specifications, and if so, that the annex reconciliation format be amended to distinguish them.*

That was all she asked for. A clarification and a form change. She was rather pleased with how boring she had made it.

She filed it Tuesday, 08:14, and the ledger gave her back a receipt hash, and she went and did lots eleven through nineteen.

The file came back on Friday.

STATUS: CLOSED. DISPOSITION: NO ACTION REQUIRED. NOTE: VARIANCE WITHIN ANNEX TOLERANCE. RECONCILIATION FORMAT UNDER REVIEW BY COMMISSION AHEAD OF RENEWAL; SUBMISSIONS SUSPENDED.

Time between filing and closure: seventy-nine hours, which included a weekend.

She stood in the corridor outside Stall Two with her earpiece around her neck and read it three times and could not find the part that was wrong, which was the annoying bit. Every sentence was true. The variance was within tolerance. The format was under review; she'd had the circular in March and deleted it.

"Two millihertz proud," she said to nobody.

Karabo went past with a spider wrench and said, "Sorry?"

"Nothing. Get me the service book for Five."

Stall Five's driver ring had been changed in February. Pickups replaced last August, both. Calibration against the bar within four millihertz every week for fourteen months, initialled, dated, temperature logged. The stall was not sick. Naledi had known that before she asked. She asked because a person who files a report and then does not check her own instruments is a person who will be asked why she did not check her own instruments.

Marais came down to Floor Four on the Wednesday, which was not remarkable. He came down most months. He had come out of the guild himself, forty years ago, and he still put on the earpiece and asked to hear the idle, and the floor liked him for it and the floor was not wrong to.

He asked her to walk with him on the catwalk. He was seventy-one and he walked slowly through the bore and stopped at the middle, where the glass gets that green depth in it, and put his hand on the rail.

"You know what my father did on this apron," he said. "He drove a water truck. Nineteen years."

"Ntate, I know."

"I tell everyone. It's the only story I have." He looked down the length of the bore. "Your report was good. I want to say that first, and I want you to believe I mean it, because in about four minutes you're going to think I'm managing you. It was good. The interval work especially

— you didn't chase the millihertz, you chased the ratio. That's the guild at its best and I read it twice."

"Thank you."

"It's also correct, as far as I can tell." He said it plainly, the way you'd read out a mass at contact. "I don't know what those ninety-one items are. Neither do you. Neither, I suspect, does anyone in this building. Now let me tell you what week it is."

He let go of the rail and turned to face her.

"Six weeks. The Renewal instrument is a hundred and nine pages and the volume schedule alone took four years to agree, because volume is the only clause in it that the other twenty-two signatory blocs actually fight over. China wants doubled tonnage and a shortened cycle. The Southern Carry wants the cycle held and the technique schedule front-loaded. The North American Compact wants proof it isn't paying rent. And every one of them has domestic weather that would eat their delegation alive if they came home with less than they promised."

"I know."

"You know it the way you know the weather in Chile. Let me be specific, because specific is the only thing you and I both trust." He counted on his fingers, no theatre in it. "The platinum framework is annexed to the Renewal. Not adjacent. Annexed. If the Accord lapses without instrument, forty percent of the world's platcap electrode supply falls back to bilateral contracts negotiated in a panic, and the price of a cell in Nairobi triples inside a quarter, and every mesh node in the Congo basin that runs on a two-hundred-rand cell goes dark by degrees. Second. The technique schedule. There are eleven deliveries queued behind signature, one of which is a ceramic process for piezo harvesters that halves the cost of a footfall paver. That is not glamour. That is a village in Limpopo lighting a clinic. Third, and this is the one I lose sleep on. This country has been indispensable for twenty-nine years. Do you know how long any country has ever been indispensable?"

"No."

"Neither does anyone, because nobody has been. We are hosting the species relationship on our ground, under our custody, on our terms,

and we are doing it because the Accord says so. Instruments say so. Take the instrument away and what's left is that we happen to be sitting on the gold, and the world has a long and well-documented history of arrangements for people sitting on gold." He put his hands in his pockets. "My father drove a water truck on an apron owned by other people. I would like to die before that comes back."

A hoist came up over Bay Two and the rotors sang thin and then dropped away.

"So," Naledi said. "Drop it."

"No. Hold it." He shook his head slightly. "I'm not asking you to unsee it. I'd fire you if you could. I'm asking you to be curious in September. Curiosity has a season, Naledi, and the season is the twenty-seven years we've had and the fifty we'll have after signature. We have been allowed to be curious for twenty-seven years. We get to be sovereign for six weeks. If I take a question about ninety-one guide segments onto that floor now, I don't get an answer. I get a delegation from the Give bloc saying the host nation is inventing doubt to raise the price, and a delegation from the Keep bloc saying they *told us* the metal was going somewhere unstated, and eleven technique deliveries in a drawer, and the clinic in Limpopo not lit. And I still don't have an answer, because the counterparty will file six lines and sign them and the six lines will be true."

"They usually are."

"They usually are." Something moved at the corner of his mouth. "Re-open it in September. I'll co-sign the request myself, and I'll put my name above yours on it so it isn't a junior engineer against a protocol, and I'll make sure the format review takes your amendment. That's not a bribe. That's a plan, and it's a better plan than the one where you're right in August and unemployed in October."

He waited. He was good at waiting; he'd been in rooms.

"Understood," Naledi said.

"That's not agreement."

"No, ntate. It's understanding. You asked for one and I've got it."

He laughed, actually laughed, and patted the rail twice, and went off

down the catwalk with his hand out for the rail every third step, because the floor grating is open there and he was seventy-one.

She stayed in the bore a while.

She could not tell him the real thing, which was smaller than the country and larger than a form change. Lebo had signed both sheets. Lebo, who had eighteen years on her and had taught her how to hold the mallet, had put her thumb on the plate twice in one morning and certified two items as the same component, and they were not the same component, and Naledi had let a receipt hash go into the ledger under her own thumb ninety-one times over three years without seeing it.

She had written *A-440 ok by ear* every morning of her working life and then let a machine correct her, on purpose, because she did not trust her ear, and the whole point of that discipline — the mallet, the case, the temperature log, the humiliation at eleven millihertz — was so that nothing would ever get past the house. Not *nothing important*. Nothing.

Ninety-one items had got past. Twice a week, for three years, past everybody, into the ledger, out through the bore, up.

The gallery air came up grey and broad through the grating.

She went down to the tuning office and reopened her pencil table, and started a second column, and headed it with the interval — the actual number, four places — because if family B was formed to another reference, then somewhere there was a bar somebody had struck to get it, and she was going to find out whose mallet.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor